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Ark, ship

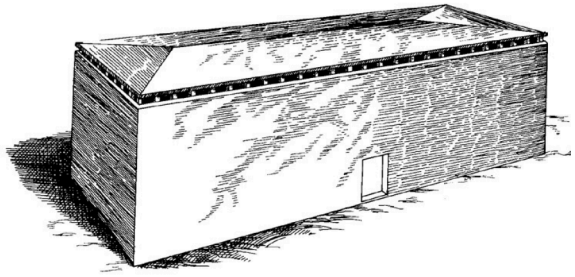
8.1.3 Ark, ship

References:

Hebrew תֵּבָה (tevah) GEN 6:14, GEN 6:14, GEN 6:15, GEN 6:16, GEN 6:16, GEN 6:18, GEN 6:19, GEN 7:1, GEN 7:7, GEN 7:9, GEN 7:13, GEN 7:15, GEN 7:17, GEN 7:18, GEN 7:23, GEN 8:1, GEN 8:4, GEN 8:6, GEN 8:9, GEN 8:9, GEN 8:10, GEN 8:13, GEN 8:16, GEN 8:19, GEN 9:10, GEN 9:18

Greek κιβωτός (kibōtos) MAT 24:38, LUK 17:27, HEB 11:7, 1PE 3:20, 2MA 2:4, 4MA 15:31, 1ES 1:3, 1ES 1:51

Description:



Noah's Ark - Artist's conception (Don Ellens, The Tabernacle of Israel, Harris, Jones 1888, Public domain)The ark was the vessel built by Noah. Its dimensions and materials are described in GEN 6:14; GEN 6:15; GEN 6:16, which gives it a length of 135–150 meters (443–492 feet), a width of 22.5–25 meters (74–82 feet), and a height of 13.5–15 meters (44–49 feet). The ark was made of wood and had three decks or levels and a roof. Each deck was divided into rooms or compartments. Except for an entrance door in its side and one window (both of unspecified size), the ark was closed in all around and would have resembled a large wooden box.

Translation:

The central meaning of both the Hebrew word *tevah* and the Greek word *kibōtos* is "box" or "chest." These words were apparently applied to Noah's vessel in view of the type of construction and the fact that it resembled more a barge than a seagoing vessel. However, in view of the size of Noah's ark, it is probably best in most languages to speak of it as a "ship."

When translating the dimensions of Noah's ark given in GEN 6:15; GEN 6:16, it is best to use modern units of measurement understood by the reader. Thus the American edition of GNT uses feet and inches, while other modern languages give the measurements in metric units (for example, SPCL and FRCL). While the exact length of the Hebrew unit used in GEN 6:0 is uncertain, it is clear that the dimensions of the ark would have made it the largest ship ever built until the early twentieth century. Where possible, translations should reflect that this was an extremely large vessel. Thus, for example, in English "ship" is preferable to "boat."